



The Ultimate Working Holiday Guide to Australia

Jobs from Entry-Level to High-Paying Positions

From Backpacker to \$200K Mining Professional — A 13-Year Journey

Job Tier Color-Coding System

 **GREEN:** Entry-Level Jobs (\$20-35/hr)

 **YELLOW:** Mid-Tier Jobs (\$45-65/hr)

 **BROWN:** Trade Jobs (\$55-80/hr)

 **BLUE:** Mining & Senior Roles (\$65-110+/hr)

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Foreword

This guide provides maximum value for those pursuing working holiday opportunities in Australia. Based on 13+ years of personal experience, it covers farming, construction, hospitality, and mining sectors — with recommendations tailored to your work history, intended stay duration, and budget.

"Wise people learn from other people's mistakes. I encourage you to learn from mine so you can avoid unnecessary suffering and bad financial decisions."

Part 1: Essential Foundations

Understanding Australian Working Holiday Visas

Visa Type	Subclass	Eligible Countries
Working Holiday visa	417	UK, Ireland, Canada, Germany, France, others
Work and Holiday visa	462	USA, Argentina, Chile, Indonesia, Vietnam, others

Basic Requirements

- Age: 18-30 years (some nationalities up to 35)
- Eligible passport with no dependent children
- Minimum funds: AUD \$5,000
- Must be outside Australia when applying for first visa
- Meet health and character requirements

Application Process

1. Create an ImmiAccount through the Australian Government immigration website
2. Start new visa application and select correct subclass
3. Fill in personal details, passport info, travel history
4. Upload documents (passport copy; 462 may need education proof)
5. Pay application fee — **AUD \$635**
6. Wait for decision — many approved within minutes

Extending Your Stay:

- **Second visa:** Complete 3 months of specified work in regional areas
- **Third visa:** Complete 6 months of specified work on your second visa
- **Total potential stay:** Up to 3 years

Tax File Number (TFN)

Apply online through the ATO website once you arrive in Australia with a valid visa (417, 462, student, etc.).

Why a Car is Your Best Investment

- Public transport in Australia is limited and unreliable
- Cars hold their value well

- Avoid expensive hostel traps (\$300+/week for shared dorms)
- One week without work can cost \$2,000+ AUD

Budget Range	Vehicle Options
\$2,000-\$7,000	Great Wall 4x4, Honda CR-V, Mitsubishi ASX, RAV4
\$8,000-\$15,000	Pajero, Kluger, Pathfinder, Navara/Triton utes
\$15,000+	Toyota Hilux, Land Cruiser Prado

Success Story: "I bought an 80-series Landcruiser at 377,000 km for \$11,000 and sold it at 417,000 km for \$14,000."

Understanding Recruitment Agencies

Used for construction, mining, and farming. Agency charges client more than they pay you (margin = profit). Example: Agency charges \$70/hr, pays you \$40/hr = \$30/hr profit.

⚠ **Key Points:** You'll mostly work on casual basis with no paid sick days or holiday pay. **Avoid Gumtree jobs** — often cash-in-hand with no insurance.

Mastering the Job Search

"Think of sending your resume like planting a seed. Then water it by calling when you don't hear back. Call at least once a week. Hearing back can take up to 3 months."

How to Call Recruitment Agencies

1. **Be calm** — don't rush or sound desperate
2. **Start with small talk** — "Hey, how are you going?"
3. **Be specific** — state your name and exact job you want
4. **Follow up** — this sets you apart from others

🔗 Understanding FIFO (Fly-In Fly-Out)

What is FIFO?

FIFO is a work arrangement common in Australian mining. Workers fly from their home city to a remote mine site, work a set roster (typically 2 weeks on, 1 week off), then fly home.

What's Included:

- ➔ **Flights:** Employer pays all flights
- 🏠 **Accommodation:** Purpose-built mining camps — FREE
- 🍽 **Meals:** All meals provided in camp mess — FREE
- 🚌 **Transport:** Bus transfers — FREE
- 🏊 **Facilities:** Gym, recreation room, WiFi, laundry



Modern FIFO mining camp in the Pilbara, WA



Resort-style FIFO village with quality amenities

💰 The Savings Advantage of Living on Camp

Why FIFO = Maximum Savings: While on camp, you have virtually ZERO living expenses!

Expense	City Living	FIFO Camp
Rent/Accommodation	\$1,600-\$2,500	\$0
Food/Groceries	\$600-\$1,000	\$0
Utilities	\$200-\$400	\$0
Transport/Fuel	\$300-\$600	\$0
TOTAL	\$2,700-\$4,500	\$0!

Real Example: Mining Labourer earning \$48/hr on a 2:1 roster:

- Weekly earnings on site: ~\$4,000+ (with overtime)
- Monthly gross: ~\$8,000-\$10,000
- **Potential annual savings: \$80,000-\$100,000+**

Common FIFO Rosters

Roster	Days On	Days Off	Best For
2:1	14	7	Most common, good balance
8:6	8	6	Better work-life balance
4:3	4	3	DIDO roles
15:13	15	13	Senior/specialist roles

 TIER 1: Entry-Level Jobs (\$20-\$28/hour)

1.1 Hospitality — Housekeeping & Cleaning

Entry-level cleaning and housekeeping roles in hotels, hostels, and resorts.

Pay: \$22-\$28/hr | Weekly: \$880-\$1,120 | Annual: \$45,000-\$58,000

Requirement	Cost	Notes
None mandatory	\$0	Basic entry-level position
RSA (optional)	\$60-\$150	Beneficial if role includes bar areas

 **Warning:** Avoid businesses offering unpaid trial days — this is illegal in Australia!

1.2 Hospitality — Restaurant & Café Work

Food service roles including waiting tables, food prep, barista work, and kitchen hand duties.

Pay: \$23-\$30/hr (casual) | Weekly: \$920-\$1,200 | Annual: \$48,000-\$62,000

Requirement	Cost	Validity
RSA (Responsible Service of Alcohol)	\$60-\$150	State-specific, 3-5 years
Food Safety Certificate	\$80-\$150	Varies by state

TIER 2: Seasonal Farm Work (\$25-\$40/hour)

2.1 Tractor Driving / Farm Hand RECOMMENDED

Operating tractors with GPS auto-steer systems for seeding, harvesting, and general farm operations.

Pay: \$28-\$40/hr | Weekly (50-60 hrs): \$1,400-\$2,400 | Seasonal: \$15,000-\$20,000+ saved

Real Example: "I saved around \$17,000 in four months driving a tractor."

Requirement	Cost	Notes
None required	\$0	Farmland is private — no licenses needed
First Aid (optional)	\$100-\$150	Some farms prefer this

Seeding Seasons:

Crop Type	Season	Regions
Winter crops	April-June	WA, SA, VIC, NSW
Summer crops	Sept-Dec	Northern NSW, QLD

Key Benefits:  Food & accommodation usually supplied |  Counts towards 88 days for visa |  No experience necessary |  No licenses needed

2.2 Fruit Picking NOT RECOMMENDED

⚠ AVOID:

- Paid by piece rate — often \$15-\$25/hour effective
- "Working hostels" overcharge for accommodation
- Exposure to pesticides causing rashes
- Inconsistent work (sent home when it rains)

TIER 3: Construction Work (\$35-\$50/hour)

3.1 Construction Labourer

General labouring including material handling, site cleanup, basic trades assistance, and operating small equipment.

Pay: \$35-\$45/hr | Daily: \$350-\$450 | Weekly: \$1,750-\$2,250 | Annual: \$85,000-\$115,000

Real Example: "My French friends earned \$400 a day each for a couple of months in construction outside the city."

Required Tickets:

Requirement	Cost	Validity
White Card (Construction Induction)	\$80-\$150	No expiry
Standard Driver's License	—	Varies
Manual Handling Certificate	\$80-\$120	3 years

Optional But Valuable:

Ticket	Cost	Benefit
Working at Heights	\$200-\$350	More job opportunities
EWP (Elevated Work Platform)	\$250-\$400	Operate scissor/boom lifts
Forklift License (LF)	\$250-\$400	Warehouse/site work

3.2 Traffic Controller

Pay: \$35-\$50/hr | Daily: \$350-\$500 | Weekly: \$1,750-\$2,500 | Annual: \$80,000-\$120,000

Requirement	Cost	Validity
Traffic Controller Ticket	\$250-\$400	3 years
White Card	\$80-\$150	No expiry
First Aid Certificate	\$100-\$150	3 years

Rigging & Scaffolding Careers (\$45-\$65/hour)

High-demand mid-tier roles across mining, construction, and oil & gas sectors.



Industrial rigging - crane and heavy lifting



Crane rigging in mining operations

 Rigging Career Levels

Riggers safely move heavy loads using cranes, hoists, and lifting equipment.

Level	Description	Pay
Dogging	Entry-level: directing crane operators, loads up to 20t	\$40-\$50/hr
Basic Rigging	Equipment setup, structural steel erection	\$45-\$55/hr
Intermediate	Multi-crane lifts, complex load calculations	\$55-\$65/hr
Advanced	Heavy machinery, structures over 20t	\$60-\$75/hr

 Scaffolding Career Levels

Scaffolders erect, alter, and dismantle temporary work platforms.

Level	Description	Pay
Basic	Prefab modular scaffolds, restricted heights	\$40-\$50/hr
Intermediate	Modular and tube scaffolds	\$50-\$60/hr
Advanced	Hung/suspended scaffolds, complex structures	\$55-\$70/hr

 **Annual Potential:**

Intermediate Rigger (FIFO): \$120,000-\$150,000/year

Advanced Scaffolder (Shutdown): \$130,000-\$160,000/year

Career Progression:

1

Start: Trade Assistant/Labourer — Get White Card

2

Get Licensed: Basic/Intermediate HRW Licence (1-2 weeks)

3

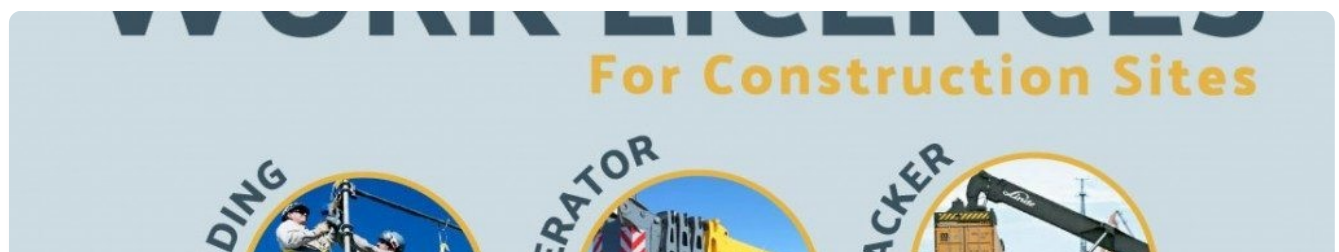
Gain Experience: 6-12 months site experience

4

Advanced: Mining FIFO or Shutdown Work — \$60-\$75/hr

High Risk Work Licences (HRW)

Nationally recognized credentials required by law for specific high-risk activities.



High risk work activities requiring licences



National HRW Licence Card

Types of HRW Licences

Class	Description	Cost	Duration
DG	Dogging	\$800-\$1,200	3-5 days
RB	Basic Rigging	\$1,000-\$1,500	5 days
RI	Intermediate Rigging	\$1,200-\$1,800	5-7 days
RA	Advanced Rigging	\$1,500-\$2,500	5-7 days
SB	Basic Scaffolding	\$800-\$1,200	3-5 days
SI	Intermediate Scaffolding	\$1,000-\$1,500	5 days
LF	Forklift	\$250-\$400	1-2 days
WP	Boom-type EWP	\$300-\$500	1-2 days

Why WA is Best for Getting Licensed:

- ✓ More training providers = competitive prices
- ✓ Mining companies often pay for tickets once employed
- ✓ Immediate job opportunities
- ✓ Construction Training Fund may reimburse costs

Process to Get HRW Licence:

1. Choose an RTO (TAFE WA, Nara Training, iCollege)
2. Complete training course (theory + practical)
3. Pass the assessment
4. Apply to WorkSafe WA with your NOA
5. Receive licence card — valid 5 years Australia-wide

Training Providers in WA:

Provider	Location	Speciality
TAFE WA	Perth, Joondalup	Full range of HRW courses
Nara Training	Perth, Kalgoorlie	Mining-focused
iCollege	Perth	Construction tickets
ERGT Australia	Perth	Oil & gas, mining safety

 TIER 4: Mining Labourer & Trade Assistant (\$48-\$55/hour)

Mining Labourer / Trade Assistant

General support work including ventilation maintenance, pipe installation, equipment moving, ground support, and assisting tradespeople.

Pay: \$48-\$55/hr (nights up to \$60+/hr) | **Daily:** \$576-\$660 | **Roster:** 2:1
Annual: \$110,000-\$140,000

Required Tickets:

Requirement	Cost	Validity
Standard 11 (Underground Induction)	\$300-\$500	5 years
Working at Heights	\$200-\$350	2-5 years
Confined Space	\$250-\$400	2-5 years
First Aid	\$100-\$150	3 years
Driver's License (C Class)	—	—

134,009

Mining Jobs in WA

47%

of AU Mining Workforce

11,065

New Workers by 2029

\$200K+

Top Earner Potential

Why WA Dominates:

- 🏆 Iron Ore Capital: 65,496 FTE jobs in Pilbara
- 🏆 Gold Rush: 35,672 FTE jobs in Goldfields
- 📈 40% of Australia's resource workforce growth
- ⚡ Critical skills shortage = easier to get hired
- ➔ Perth is the FIFO gateway

🔧 Shutdown Work

Intensive maintenance periods requiring large numbers of workers for short contracts.

Why Shutdowns are GOLD for Backpackers:

- 💰 Premium Pay: 10-20% higher rates
- 📅 Flexible: 2-6 week contracts
- 🔄 Year-Round: Different mines have different schedules
- 🧑‍🔧 Experience: Learn from experienced tradespeople

Major WA Mining Regions:

Region	Commodities	Major Employers
Pilbara	Iron Ore	BHP, Rio Tinto, FMG, Roy Hill
Goldfields	Gold, Nickel	Northern Star, Evolution
Mid West	Iron Ore, Gold	Karara Mining, Westgold
South West	Alumina, Lithium	Alcoa, Talison Lithium

Finding Shutdown Work:

- **Agencies:** Programmed, Hays, Chandler Macleod, WorkPac
- **Job Boards:** SEEK, Indeed
- **Direct:** FMS Group, Premium Mechanical Group, Centurion

Trade Careers: Boilermaker & Fitter (\$55-\$80/hour)

The backbone of mining and construction — formal qualifications with exceptional earning potential.

Boilermaker

Fabricating, assembling, and repairing metal structures, tanks, pressure vessels, and heavy equipment.

Pay: \$55-\$80/hr | Daily: \$660-\$960 | **Annual (FIFO): \$140,000-\$180,000+**

Requirement	How to Get It
Cert III Engineering - Fabrication Trade	Apprenticeship (3-4 yrs) OR RPL
Welding Certifications (AS1796)	TAFE or RTO course
Mine site tickets	Standard 11, Heights, Confined Space

Fitter / Mechanical Fitter

Installing, maintaining, and repairing machinery and mechanical equipment.

Pay: \$55-\$75/hr | Daily: \$660-\$900 | **Annual (FIFO): \$130,000-\$170,000**

Requirement	How to Get It
Cert III Engineering - Mechanical Trade	Apprenticeship (3-4 yrs) OR RPL
Hydraulics knowledge	On-the-job or courses
Mine site tickets	Standard 11, Heights, Confined Space

TIER 5: Mining — Experienced Operators (\$65-\$85/hour)

Machinery Operator

Operating heavy machinery — dump trucks, loaders (CAT 996), excavators on surface or underground mines.

Pay: \$55-\$75/hr | **Daily:** \$660-\$900 | **Roster:** 2:1 | **Annual:** \$130,000-\$170,000

Required Tickets:

Requirement	Cost	Notes
HR License (Heavy Rigid)	\$1,500-\$3,000	Required for site driving
Machinery VOCs	\$400-\$1,000 each	Site-specific assessments
Standard 11 / Site Induction	\$300-\$500	5 years

Common Machinery VOCs:

Equipment	Cost
Articulated Dump Truck (ADT)	\$500-\$1,000
CAT 996 Loader	\$500-\$1,000
Excavator	\$500-\$1,000
Grader	\$500-\$1,000
Water Cart	\$300-\$500

TIER 6: Mining — Senior & Specialist (\$85-\$110+/hour)

Mineral Process Operator

Safe processing of ore, fault-finding, communication with control room, SAP for maintenance scheduling.

Pay: \$70-\$90/hr | **Daily:** \$840-\$1,080 | **Roster:** 15:13
Annual: \$170,000-\$210,000+

Real Example: "I currently work paying close to \$200K per year on a 15-day-on, 13-day-off roster."

Requirements:

- All Tier 4 & 5 tickets
- Process Plant Induction
- SAP/Maintenance Systems knowledge
- Dangerous Goods License (\$200-\$400)
- HR License (unrestricted)

RPL: Fast-Track to Trade Qualified

What is RPL?

RPL converts your existing work experience into a nationally recognized qualification — **WITHOUT years of apprenticeship!**

Think of it as getting credit for what you already know how to do.

Why RPL is a Game-Changer

- ⌚ **Time:** Get qualified in weeks, not 3-4 years
- 💰 **Pay Boost:** Trade workers earn 30-50% more
- 📈 **Jump:** From \$48/hr (assistant) to \$65+/hr (tradesperson)
- 📜 **Licences:** Required for many contractor licences

How RPL Works:

1. **Free Assessment:** Initial eligibility check
2. **Evidence Collection:** Resume, photos, references, certificates
3. **Assessment:** Qualified assessor reviews against standards
4. **Gap Training:** Short courses if needed
5. **Qualification:** Receive nationally recognized Cert III

Available Through RPL:

Qualification	Experience Needed	Cost
Cert III Fabrication (Boilermaker)	2-3 years	\$2,000-\$4,000
Cert III Mechanical (Fitter)	2-3 years	\$2,000-\$4,000
Cert III Carpentry	2-3 years	\$1,500-\$3,500
Cert III Civil Construction	2-3 years	\$1,500-\$3,500

🔑 **Pro Tip:** If you have trade experience from your home country, RPL can convert it to Australian qualifications — opening doors to much higher-paying roles immediately!

RPL Providers:

- TAFE Queensland — tafeqld.edu.au
- Trade Skills Australia — tradeskillsaustralia.com.au
- Qualify Me! — qualifyme.edu.au
- Gimbal Group — gimbalgroup.com.au

TAFE Courses & Earning Potential

TAFE offers practical, industry-focused training to boost your earning potential.

Welding Courses — High Demand

Course	Duration	Cost	Pay Boost
Intro to Welding	3 days	~\$600	Trade assistant roles
AS1796 Certification	2-10 weeks	\$1,500-\$1,800	+\$5-10/hr
TIG Certification	1-3 weeks	\$765	Premium TIG rates
Cert III Fabrication	12-48 months	\$3,000-\$27,800	Full trade

AS1796 Welding Tickets:

Ticket	Process	Demand
Ticket 1	MMA - Plate	High
Ticket 2	MMA - Pipe	Very High
Ticket 3E/3F	MIG/MAG	High
Ticket 5	TIG - Light gauge	Premium
Ticket 7	TIG - Pipe	Premium

Earning Potential:

- Trade Assistant (no tickets): \$35-45/hr
- Welder with AS1796: \$50-65/hr
- Coded Welder (mining): \$65-85/hr
- **Annual difference: \$30,000-\$50,000+ more!**

Construction Industry Training Fund

The CITB offers funding and subsidies for construction training. **Get your tickets reimbursed!**

What Funding is Available?

For Workers:

- Up to **\$3,000 in training subsidies annually**
- Covers HRW Licences, Working at Heights, Confined Space, EWP, Forklift
- Need a CITB number (free to apply)

How to Get Reimbursed:

1. **Get CITB Number:** Apply free at citb.org.au
2. **Choose Approved Training**
3. **Provide Your Number:** Give to training provider at enrollment
4. **Subsidy Applied:** Automatically applied to course fee

Example Savings:

- Intermediate Rigging: \$1,500 → After subsidy: ~\$500-800
- Heights + Confined Space: \$600 → After subsidy: ~\$200-300

State Training Authorities:

State	Authority	Website
SA	CITB	citb.org.au
WA	Jobs and Skills WA	jobsandskills.wa.gov.au
QLD	Construction Skills QLD	csq.org.au
NSW	Training Services NSW	training.nsw.gov.au
VIC	Skills Victoria	skills.vic.gov.au

Oil & Gas Offshore Pathways

Highest-paying opportunities in Australia — requires specific certifications and significant investment.

Is Offshore Right for You?

Factor	Consideration
Visa Duration	Need 6+ months to make investment worthwhile
Budget	Minimum \$3,000-5,000 for certifications
Physical Fitness	Demanding, strict medical requirements
Commitment	2-4 weeks offshore at a time

Essential Offshore Tickets

Certification	Cost	Duration	Validity
BOSIET with CA-EBS	\$2,000-\$2,500	2 days	4 years
MSIC	\$100-\$150	1-2 weeks	5 years
Offshore Medical	\$300-\$500	Same day	2 years
FOET (refresher)	\$800-\$1,200	1 day	4 years

Offshore Career Pathways

Entry Level:

- **Roustabout:** General labouring — \$50-65/hr
- **Galley Hand:** Catering — \$40-55/hr
- **Stores/Logistics:** Inventory — \$50-60/hr

Experienced:

- **Derrickman:** Drilling operations — \$65-85/hr
- **Crane Operator:** Heavy lifting — \$70-90/hr
- **Production Tech:** Process ops — \$70-95/hr

Senior:

- **Driller:** Team leader — \$85-120/hr
- **OIM:** Platform commander — \$150,000-\$300,000/year

Recommendations by Situation

🕒 6-12 months on visa:

Start with onshore mining to build experience first. Offshore companies prefer candidates with Australian work history.

🕒 1-2 years remaining:

Excellent time to invest. Get experience onshore (6 months), then target offshore.

💰 Tight budget:

Focus on mining first — similar pay, lower entry costs. Use mining income to fund offshore tickets later.

Training Provider:

- **ERGT Australia** (Perth) — ergt.edu.au — Premier oil & gas training

Investment Summary — Tickets & Licenses

Starter Package (\$500-\$800)

For: Hospitality, Farming, Entry-level Construction

Ticket	Cost	Opens Jobs In
White Card	\$100	All construction sites
RSA	\$80	Hospitality
First Aid	\$150	All industries
Manual Handling	\$100	All manual work
Total	~\$430	—

Construction Package (\$1,500-\$2,500)

For: Construction labouring, traffic control, warehouse

Ticket	Cost
White Card	\$100
Working at Heights	\$300
EWP License	\$350
Forklift License	\$350
Traffic Controller	\$350
First Aid	\$150
Total	~\$1,600

Mining Starter Package (\$3,000-\$5,000)

For: Entry-level mining, trade assistant

Ticket	Cost
Standard 11 Induction	\$450
Working at Heights	\$300
Confined Space	\$350
First Aid	\$150
Manual Handling	\$100
HR License	\$2,000
Total	~\$3,350

Rigging/Scaffolding Package (\$4,000-\$6,000)

For: Mid-tier mining and construction roles

Ticket	Cost
All Mining Starter tickets	\$3,350
Intermediate Rigging/Scaffolding	\$1,200-\$1,500
Total	~\$4,500-\$5,000

Job Progression Roadmap

1

● **TIER 1: Hospitality (\$22-\$28/hr)**
Investment: \$0-\$150 | Immediate start

2

● **TIER 2: Farm Work (\$28-\$40/hr)**
Investment: \$0 | Get 88 days here!

3

● **TIER 3: Construction (\$35-\$50/hr)**
Investment: \$500-\$2,500 | 1-3 months

4

● **TIER 4: Mining Labourer (\$48-\$55/hr)**
Investment: \$3,000-\$5,000 | 1-3 months

4b

● **Rigging & Scaffolding (\$45-\$65/hr)**
Investment: \$4,000-\$6,000 | 3-6 months experience

5

● **Trade Qualified (\$55-\$80/hr)**
Investment: RPL \$2,000-\$4,000 OR Apprenticeship

6

● **TIER 5: Mining Operator (\$55-\$75/hr)**
Investment: \$6,000-\$10,000 | 6-12 months experience

7

● **TIER 6: Mining Senior (\$70-\$90+/hr)**
Investment: Ongoing | 2-5+ years experience
POTENTIAL: \$170,000-\$200,000+/year

Final Advice

Australian Work Culture

"Being German, I struggled with the idea of having to be perfect. Australia is different — it really is 'easy going.' Show willingness to learn, listen, and don't be arrogant."

The Key to Success

Your interpersonal skills matter more than experience for lower-tier jobs. Show willingness to learn, be humble, and demonstrate reliability.

Avoiding Common Mistakes

1. **Don't get trapped in hostels** — expensive accommodation drains savings
2. **Don't travel in large groups** — job searching is more effective alone
3. **Don't limit yourself geographically** — apply Australia-wide
4. **Don't buy the cheapest car** — repairs can cost more than the vehicle
5. **Don't work cash-in-hand** — no insurance, no protection
6. **Don't accept unpaid trials** — it's illegal in Australia

Essential Websites

Resource	URL	Purpose
Seek	seek.com.au	Job listings
Indeed	au.indeed.com	Job listings
Immigration	immi.homeaffairs.gov.au	Visa applications
TFN Application	ato.gov.au	Tax File Number

This guide represents 13+ years of real experience. Follow the journey, learn from these mistakes, and create your own Australian success story.

Document Version: Professional Edition v2.0

Last Updated: February 2026

Organization: Jobs arranged from lower-paying to higher-paying positions with clear requirements and color-coding